

A PRACTICAL GUIDE + WORKBOOK

Bea's Calm-Alone Guide



Understand the moments around leaving.
Keep track of the small steps.
Make room for your dog's individual needs.

An owner-created educational companion.
No fixed timetable. No promised cure.

CONTENTS

Your guide at a glance

Start here	3
Your quick-start map	4
Understand the behaviour	5
Read the whole dog	6
Prepare the environment	7
Plan for ordinary life	8
Find a comfortable start	9
Departure cues, gently	10
Organise a short session	11
Progress without a deadline	12
When things get difficult	13
Review and maintain	14
An example, not a target	15
Terms and further reading	16

01 / A KINDER START

Start here

This guide is a practical companion for noticing what happens around alone time, organising small steps and keeping useful records. It is an owner-created educational resource, not an individual treatment plan. Use it alongside professional advice when your dog finds separation difficult.

Meet Bea

Bea is the dog behind Bea & Co. Her photo belongs here because this project starts with a real dog and the person who cares for her. This guide does not claim that every dog will follow the same path, or promise a particular outcome.

How to use the kit

Read the guide before attempting exercises. Open the separate workbook and save a copy with your dog's name. Complete the starting-point page, keep one session record at a time, then review patterns with your support professional. Print fresh pages whenever you need them.

When this guide is not enough

Arrange a veterinary assessment for suspected separation-related distress, especially with new symptoms or toileting changes. Injury, frantic escape attempts or severe distress need prompt professional help. Do not run an absence test to prove that a dog is struggling. Medication decisions belong with your veterinarian. [1]

No fixed recovery time is promised. A quiet dog is not automatically a comfortable dog. The aim is to understand the individual in front of you, not to reach a number on a calendar.

02 / READ BEFORE PRACTISING

Your quick-start map

1. Understand the starting point

Write down what you already know: what happens before departures, which situations are easier, and whether someone can remain with your dog. Existing video may be useful; you do not need to provoke distress to gather evidence.

2. Make daily life manageable

List realistic cover for necessary absences. A trusted person staying with your dog may help, but confirm that your dog is comfortable with that arrangement. A walk halfway through a long absence does not provide company during the time before and after it.

3. Choose an achievable action

An action can be as small as approaching a door while remaining in view. Start with something your dog already handles comfortably. If even that is difficult, work with a qualified professional rather than improvising increasingly stressful tests.

4. Observe, return, record

Watch the whole dog. Return promptly if distress appears; do not wait for silence as a condition of returning. Record the exact action and what you saw. Give your dog time to settle, and stop if you are unsure.

5. Review before changing anything

Use observations across sessions to inform the next choice. A good day is useful information, not permission for a large jump. Your professional can help translate the records into an individual plan.

Keep the one-page Quick Reference nearby. It is a reminder of the guide, not a shortcut around reading it.

03 / CONTEXT COMES FIRST

Understand the behaviour

Barking, damage or toileting during an absence can have different explanations. The label "separation anxiety" should not be inferred from a damaged door or a neighbour's report alone. This guide uses "separation-related distress" descriptively, without diagnosing your dog.

Look for a pattern

Record when the behaviour begins, what was happening just before it, whether the dog was alone, and whether noises or confinement may have played a part. Write observations such as "walked between the door and window" instead of conclusions such as "was angry with me".

What this changes

Treat difficulty as information. Punishment is not an appropriate response to separation-related distress. Video can help you see patterns that are otherwise hidden when you return home. Consult your veterinarian if symptoms persist or their cause is unclear. [2]

Keep the goal realistic

A useful goal describes a situation your household needs to manage and the support available while you work toward it. "Arrange comfortable cover for Tuesday morning" may be more useful today than "reach two hours by Friday".

A note for the human

You do not need perfect records or a perfect routine to begin organising support. Use short, factual notes. If the process is overwhelming, reduce the administrative burden and ask for help. The workbook is meant to make decisions easier.

04 / OBSERVATION

Read the whole dog

Compare behaviour with your dog's usual relaxed state. Record posture, movement, breathing, sounds and ability to settle together. A single yawn, a refused snack or one bark does not establish a diagnosis.

Possible observations to record

Repeated pacing; sustained vocalising; trembling; drooling; panting without an obvious explanation; repeated checking of an exit; tense stillness; attempts to escape; or a change in eating. Note the circumstances instead of assigning meaning automatically.

Use precise words

"Whale eye" describes visible eye white; it is not the same as a dilated pupil. Write down what you can actually see. If the camera angle is poor, mark the observation as uncertain rather than assuming your dog was calm.

Quiet is not the only goal

A dog can be silent while remaining tense. Likewise, eating does not prove that the whole absence was comfortable. Observe the period before, during and after any activity, including what happens when a food toy is finished.

A simple recording key

Comfortable: behaviour looks like the dog's relaxed baseline.

Uncertain: you cannot confidently interpret the behaviour or see the dog.

Distress: concerning changes, escalation or clear difficulty are present.

This key is an organisational tool, not a validated clinical scale. Uncertain is a reason to pause and review, not a green light to make the exercise harder.

05 / BEFORE THE DOOR

Prepare the environment

Choose familiar comfort

Use a space your dog already finds comfortable. Check access to water, temperature, resting places and household hazards. Closing a gate or crate can change the situation, so do not assume a smaller space will be easier.

Observe without leaving the dog unsupported

For live exercises, use a live camera or video call with a reliable view and sound, and stay close enough to return immediately. A recording you can only watch later is useful for review, but cannot alert you to distress during practice.

Keep tools optional

A notebook and a way to observe may be enough. No particular camera, diffuser or toy is required by this guide. If you use enrichment, choose something appropriate for your dog and already assessed for safe use. Food is not a substitute for a suitable absence plan.

Make the comparison fair

Record factors that could affect a session: visitors, unusual noise, poor sleep, a change of room or who is home. Do not change several elements at once and then assume duration alone explains the result.

Before starting

Check: the dog is settled; you can observe; you know the planned action; you can return at once; and you have time to record what happened. If one of these is missing, choose an observation or planning task instead.

06 / YOUR SUPPORT PLAN

Plan for ordinary life

Training and unavoidable real-world absences are different problems. A workable plan accounts for both. Use the support page to identify when company is needed and who can provide it.

Match support to the dog

A familiar sitter at home, a trusted friend or another arrangement may work. Check the dog's comfort with the person and place before relying on it. Daycare or another dog is not automatically the right fit.

Plan the entire absence

Write departure and return times, travel margins and a backup contact. Clarify whether the helper will remain throughout the absence. Record what should happen if plans change or the dog becomes distressed.

If an unavoidable absence happens

Use the safest feasible arrangement and seek help with ongoing gaps. Record the event separately from planned practice. Do not treat a difficult real-world absence as a training success because it lasted longer.

Return to observation

After a disruption, assess the dog's current comfort instead of trying to recover lost minutes. A previous record remains useful history, but it is not a guarantee of what the dog can manage today.

Support is part of the plan. Asking for company, adjusting a schedule or consulting a professional is a practical response to the problem, not a failure of commitment.

07 / NO STRESS TEST

Find a comfortable start

The original guide called this finding the threshold. Here, think of a comfortable starting point: a known action that does not visibly concern your dog. You do not need to discover the longest possible absence.

Use existing information first

Note an action your dog already tolerates, such as you shifting in your chair or moving toward a doorway. Closing the front door is not a universal first step. Some dogs need support before any out-of-sight practice is appropriate.

Record one clear action

Include the location, who was home, what you did and what the dog did. For example: "Stood beside the hallway door; stayed visible; dog remained resting." This is an example of notation, not an instruction that every dog should repeat it.

If uncertainty appears

Stop the exercise, rejoin your dog and review the observation. Do not repeat the action until the dog appears fully settled simply to obtain a better-looking record. Discuss ambiguous signals with your professional.

Before you progress

You should be able to describe what comfortable behaviour looked like and why the next action is appropriate. If you cannot, the next task is more observation or professional guidance, not a longer absence.

Keep your starting-point record dated. It is a snapshot of a particular situation, not a permanent score for your dog.

08 / AN INDIVIDUAL STEP

Departure cues, gently

Keys, shoes or a bag may become noticeable parts of leaving. Observe whether those cues actually concern your dog. A dog who is comfortable with keys does not need a mandatory week of key exercises.

Keep the action small

If your professional recommends cue practice, begin with a manageable version and change one element at a time. Do not repeatedly jingle keys at an already worried dog to make the reaction disappear.

Avoid rigid repetition targets

There is no prescribed number of repetitions in this workbook. Write down what happened and allow recovery between activities. A stressed dog does not need extra repetitions to finish a quota.

Combine only when appropriate

Several individually easy actions may become harder when combined. Putting on shoes, lifting a bag and touching a handle is a different event from any one of those actions alone. Record the combination explicitly.

What to write

Cue or action; context; response; recovery; and the proposed next step. Keep plans separate from observations so you can tell what was intended and what actually happened.

Progress is not measured by whether the dog ignores you completely. Look for comfort in context, and have a qualified professional help if you are unsure how to interpret the response.

09 / PLAN, OBSERVE, RECORD

Organise a short session

Before

Read the previous record. Choose an action within current comfort and write it down. Confirm that live observation and a prompt return are possible. Decide in advance to stop if the dog becomes unsettled or you lose the camera view.

During

Perform the planned action while observing the dog. Do not extend it spontaneously because things seem to be going well. If distress appears, return promptly and calmly; do not require quiet before returning.

After

Allow the dog to settle. Record the actual duration and unit, or write "no absence" for an in-view action. Describe the response, not just whether you consider it a success. Do not start another departure while the dog remains unsettled.

Decide what comes next

Comfortable: record it and review the overall pattern before changing difficulty.

Uncertain: pause and review the video or ask for help.

Distress: stop, return to an easier plan and seek support if needed.

Make greetings natural

Keep your manner calm and reassuring. This guide does not require you to withhold affection or ignore your dog. The useful question is whether the routine supports comfort, not whether you performed an exact greeting ritual.

Session frequency, progression and rest should suit the individual dog. More departures are not automatically better.

10 / COMFORT BEFORE DURATION

Progress without a deadline

Avoid fixed weekly targets and automatic jumps from seconds to minutes or from minutes to hours. The workbook does not prescribe a universal timetable. Agree individual progression with the professional supporting you.

Change one thing you can describe

Duration, the door used, time of day, departure cues and who is home can all change the experience. Record the change. A comfortable practice in one setting does not demonstrate comfort in every setting.

Measure the pattern

Look at several records together. Was the dog comfortable throughout? Was recovery easy? Was the camera view adequate? Did a longer duration coincide with uncertainty? The largest number is not necessarily the most useful result.

Keep units explicit

Write 3 seconds, not just 3. Use seconds for micro-absences and minutes only when appropriate. Avoid rounding an absence upward or treating planned time as actual time.

No milestone guarantees

Reaching a particular duration does not guarantee readiness for a much longer absence. Plan real-life needs separately, including appropriate care, company and breaks for the dog.

A sensible review can conclude "repeat an easier action" or "ask for advice". The record should help you make that decision, not pressure you to produce a rising graph.

11 / TROUBLESHOOTING

When things get difficult

The dog seemed comfortable yesterday

Record what changed and reassess today. Do not insist on yesterday's duration. New or persistent changes warrant a veterinary discussion, especially if the dog seems unwell.

The dog will not eat

Note when it happened, what was offered and other behaviour. Refusing food is not a stand-alone diagnosis; eating is not proof of comfort either. Do not increase food value to justify an otherwise difficult absence.

The camera failed

End the exercise and restore observation before trying again. Mark the record as uncertain rather than assuming the unseen period went well.

I do not have enough time

Prioritise support arrangements and a manageable record. Ask your professional to help design a feasible schedule. Do not squeeze repeated departures into a short break at the expense of the dog's recovery.

The dog is vocalising or trying to escape

Return promptly, make the situation safe and stop the exercise. Seek prompt veterinary help for injury or severe distress. Do not wait outside for the dog to stop as a training rule.

I cannot tell whether this is working

Bring a few representative records and videos to a qualified professional. Include uncertainty and setbacks; those entries can be more informative than the best-looking session.

12 / A USEFUL WEEKLY CHECK-IN

Review and maintain

Review the week, not a streak

Use the weekly page to record comfortable situations, concerning changes, support that worked and questions for your next appointment. Leave gaps when no exercise happened. There is no streak to protect.

Keep maintenance individual

Continue observing your dog when routines change. Moving house, different work hours or a new caregiver may require a fresh plan. Do not assume past performance automatically transfers to a new setting.

Know what your records cannot prove

A session log is your observation, not a diagnosis, controlled study or guarantee. Be honest about missing footage, distractions and unknowns. Your notes can support a professional conversation without replacing one.

Make the kit work for you

Duplicate only the pages you use. You may prefer a paper log, a saved PDF or short notes transferred later. Store videos separately with filenames that match the date and session record. Avoid collecting more detail than you can maintain.

The practical goal

A clearer picture of your dog, a more workable support plan and records that make the next conversation easier. Let those be the measures of this workbook's usefulness.

Bea & Co. / Small steps. Thoughtful care.

13 / HOW TO COMPLETE A RECORD

An example, not a target

The following record is fictional and illustrates how to write observations. It is not Bea's history, a testimonial or a recommended exercise sequence.

A clearly recorded session

Context: Tuesday, quiet afternoon; caregiver at home.

Planned action: stand near the hallway door while remaining visible.

Actual absence: none.

Observed: dog lifted head briefly, then returned to resting posture.

Recording key: comfortable, based on usual resting behaviour.

Next note: review with the existing plan; do not infer readiness for a closed door.

A clearly recorded uncertainty

Context: another day; dog moved out of camera view.

Observed: could not see posture or movement.

Recording key: uncertain.

Action taken: returned and ended the activity.

Next note: adjust camera before any further exercise.

Why this is useful

Both records distinguish what happened from what is unknown. Neither uses a vague "passed" label or treats silence as enough evidence. The next step remains a decision, not an automatic longer duration.

Use the same standard for your own notes: short, observable and honest. The blank workbook contains more room for writing than this example.

14 / REFERENCES

Terms and further reading

A short glossary

Comfortable starting point: an action currently observed to be manageable.

Desensitisation: carefully graded exposure used in behaviour work.

Counterconditioning: changing an association through pairing with something positive.

Departure cue: something that may predict leaving.

Management: arrangements that help meet the dog's needs in daily life.

Further reading

[1] ASPCA. [Separation Anxiety](#). Medical assessment and professional support for individual behaviour plans.

[2] RSPCA. [Separation Anxiety in Dogs](#). Recognising separation-related behaviour, observation and seeking help.

[3] Merck Veterinary Manual. [Behavior Problems of Dogs](#). Professional reference on behavioural assessment and management.

About this edition

Revised from the owner-supplied Bea's Calm-Alone Protocol. Educational guide and organisational workbook; not a veterinary prescription or a clinically validated programme. Referenced organisations have not endorsed this product. Individual outcomes and timescales vary.

Edition 2 / September 2026. Copyright Bea & Co. Personal use: save and print copies for your household. Do not redistribute or resell the files. Keep the workbook private when it contains personal information.